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22. Bhavna Vij-Arora, 'The caste of poll saffron', *Outlook*, 21 May 2018, https://www.outlookindia.com/magazine/story/the-caste-of-poll-saffron/300140; Faisal Fareed, 'Tug of war in UP over legacy of Rajbhar king', *The Indian Express*, 29 February 2016, https://indianexpress.com/article/cities/lucknow/tug-of-war-in-up-over-legacy-of-rajbhar-king/.

23. PMO India YouTube video, 'PM Modi releases commemorative stamp on Maharaja Suheldev and address public rally in Ghazipur', 28 December 2018, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ood3ZDg6Koc. For an account on the historical traditions for Raja Suheldev among Pasis, see Badri Narayan, 'Memories, saffronising statues and constructing communal politics', *Economic & Political Weekly*, Vol. 41, No. 45, 11–17 November 2006, pp. 4697–4698. For a critical account of Suheldev, see, for example, Ajaz Ashraf, 'How Amit Shah and BJP have twisted the story of Salar Masud and Raja Suheldev', 17 July 2017, https://scroll.in/article/841590/how-amit-shah-and-the-bjp-have-twisted-the-story-of-salar-masud-and-raja-suheldev. Suheldev's battle with Mahmud of Ghazni is also the subject of a recent novel by the best-selling writer Amish, *Legend of Suheldev: The King Who Saved India* (New Delhi: Westland, 2020).

24. The Lok Sabha constituencies where Nishads are said to have influence include: Firozabad, Badaun, Shahjahanpur, Kairana, Machhlishahr, Jaunpur. They also have a sizeable presence in Ghazipur, Phulpur, Sitapur, Jalaun, Fatehpur, Unnao, Gorakhpur, Ballia and Deoria, according to UP Backward Class Finance and Development Corporation Chairperson Baburam Nishad. PTI, 'Amit Shah woos Nishads, promises to build 8-feet tall statue of Nishadraj', News18.com, 10 May 2019, https://www.news18.com/news/politics/in-up-amit-shah-woos-nishads-promises-to-build-80-feet-tall-statue-of-nishadraj-2135337.html. For an analysis on the political importance of